MVP Game Summary — [WORKING TITLE]

One-Sentence Pitch

A cozy solarpunk RPG where a small repair robot wakes on a forgotten floating island, fixes dormant infrastructure across a four-island archipelago, and builds trust-based relationships with AI characters who remember everything you say.

Game Overview

[WORKING TITLE] is a 2D isometric survival-crafting RPG. The player controls a repair robot whose pod has crashed on the shore of a forgotten floating island. The robot has limited power and no memory of how it got there. To survive and move forward, it must restore the island's broken systems, wake its dormant transmitter, and reach the next island.

The game is built on three ideas:

1. **Fixing, not fighting.** The player chops overgrowth, gathers resources, feeds fuel into machines, and repairs broken buildings. Every action is about bringing things back to working order — not destroying them.
2. **Characters who remember.** NPCs are powered by a live language model. They remember past conversations, reveal information based on how much they trust the player, and change how they speak over time. Some NPCs move between islands based on what the player does.
3. **Exploration with purpose.** Each island is a self-contained chapter. The player solves environmental puzzles, finds hidden history, chooses between routes, and activates a signal relay to reach the next island.

The art is flat 2D with warm light and a world that reacts to the player: grass sways in wind, water ripples, wind pushes the player, and cleaned solar panels sing.

Player Fantasy

You are a small repair robot. You are not a warrior or a chosen hero. You arrive after everyone else has left, and instead of fighting, you start fixing.

Chopping overgrowth gives biomass that fuels machines. Cleaning solar panels makes them sing. The transmitter glows when fed. Wind chimes ring more often as the island heals. The world does not reward you with explosions — it rewards you by getting brighter and warmer.

But the robot is fragile. Its pod has limited energy. A broken burner near the pod can be fixed to keep that energy alive — burn wood, stabilise power, buy time. The player must always balance exploring with staying alive.

And across the islands, people are waking up. A transmitter that does not know if it was a person or a tool. A girl who tells fairy tales about the old world. A grumpy old man who guards a museum of forgotten technology. A soldier who has not seen a maintenance robot in a very long time. They need time and trust. You are the first person they have spoken to in a long time.

MVP Demo: The Archipelago

The demo is a 30-minute first chapter across four floating islands. It teaches every core system — resource gathering, building repair, energy management, NPC relationships, environmental puzzles, scanning, and transmitter repair — through play, with no cutscenes or text tutorials.

Each island focuses on one or two core ideas while keeping the wider game in view.

Island 1 — The Crashed Base

Teaches: Movement, resource gathering, building repair, energy management, first NPC gate

The player wakes beside their crashed pod on a small island. The pod is flickering — its energy is low and draining. Nearby:

- A broken burner, dark and collapsed
- A dormant base transmitter
- Overgrowth covering everything
- Basic resources — wood and stone — within a short walk
- An NPC on the island, waiting

What happens:

The player explores. They find wood and stone. They swing their wrench at overgrowth — debris flies, the screen shakes, the plant falls. Resources collect automatically.

They find the broken burner near the pod. With wood and stone gathered, they repair it. The burner connects to the pod and transmitter. The player feeds wood into the burner, and the pod's energy stabilises for the first time. The transmitter stirs — a faint glow, a fragment of speech.

The pod AI guides the player through the basics: gather, repair, fuel, sustain. The island is small and safe — a place to learn the controls and the rhythm of fixing things.

The first gate:

Before leaving, the player meets an NPC who needs metal. The player must find or refine metal on the island and bring it back. The request is small and quick — an early success, not a grind. When the player delivers the metal, the NPC opens the gate to the next island, gives advice about what lies ahead, and hands over a **battery**.

The player crosses to the hub island.

Island 2 — The Hub

Teaches: NPC relationships, merchant trading, route branching, bridge repair, social links between NPCs

The second island is larger and more populated. It is where the world branches. Here the player meets:

- **A young girl** who tells stories — legends, fairy tales, rumours about the old world. She is the emotional centre of the island. She speaks about the world with wonder, not grief.
- **Her parent (or uncle)** — a merchant who sells resources and knows about the two routes off the island. He is practical and a bit guarded. If the player befriends the girl first, he warms up and offers a discount. He can also sell the player a **solar panel** — showing that buildings can be traded, and that adding more panels of the same type increases their total output.
- **A soldier** who guards one of the two routes. He scans the player, says it has been a long time since he last saw a maintenance robot, and lets the player pass.

Two routes:

Route A — The Broken Bridge: The player buys or gathers metal, repairs a collapsed bridge, and crosses to the next island. This is the simpler path — direct, and teaches that broken structures can be fixed.

Route B — The Guarded Island: The player talks to the soldier, gets scanned, and passes through to a museum island. This is the more interesting route — a wind-blocked puzzle and an old man who would rather be left alone.

Both routes lead forward, but the guarded island holds the richer story.

The girl's backpack:

If the player talks to the girl enough — asks about her stories, shows interest — trust grows. She gives the player her favourite **backpack**. It is a personal reward. The player does not know it yet, but this backpack will change how other NPCs react to them.

Island 3 — The Museum

Teaches: Wind puzzles, NPC-puzzle interaction, scanning for memories, technology salvage, building repair rewards, rope traversal

This island is an old museum of forgotten technology — dusty, wind-swept, and half-buried. A strong wind blows across the central plateau, blocking the way forward.

The grumpy old man:

An old man stands near the wind path. He is curt. He demands payment to pass — this is a museum, he says, and visitors pay. He glances at the player and adds, after a pause: *"...similar to you."*

If the player carries the **girl's backpack**, the old man recognises it. He is the girl's grandfather. He drops the fee (or cuts it heavily) and turns off the wind machine blocking the plateau. The puzzle becomes solvable.

The wind puzzle:

With the wind off, the player crosses the plateau — pushing crates, crossing gaps, using the environment to reach the far side. The puzzle teaches that environmental obstacles can be changed through NPC interaction.

The broken maintenance robot:

On the far side, the player finds a broken-down maintenance robot — like themselves. When scanned, it reveals **memory fragments**: this robot was on its way to fix a transmitter when it crashed. It had the parts needed in its pod. The memory is quiet and sad — a robot like the player, on the same mission, that did not make it.

The broken pod:

Next to the robot is its broken pod. The player breaks it open and takes **technology scrap** — the part needed to repair the final transmitter.

The rope reward:

If the player repairs some of the broken buildings on the island (an energy tower, a storage unit), the old man gives them a **rope** — a tool that opens new movement options on the final island.

The old man moves:

When the player leaves the island, they find the old man standing next to the soldier on the hub island, talking. He says that seeing his granddaughter's backpack made him want to visit his family. If the player returns to the hub later, the old man has moved again — now standing next to the merchant and the girl. This is a rare, concrete moment: an NPC whose life changed because of something the player did.

Island 4 — The Summit

Teaches: Traversal puzzle, transmitter repair, network connection — the demo's climax

The final island is a vertical climb. The player uses the rope to cross gaps, solves one last puzzle (focused on elevation and movement), and reaches the top.

At the summit stands the broken transmitter. The player uses the technology scrap from the dead robot's pod to repair it. The transmitter connects to the base transmitter on Island 1.

The demo ends.

Core Gameplay Loop

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Explore → Find something broken → Fix it (chop, clean, feed, repair) →
Watch the island change → Talk to NPCs → Build trust →
Open new routes, story, and objectives → Reach the next island
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Each pass through this loop deepens both the world and the relationships:

- **The world changes:** islands get brighter as systems come online. Burners keep pod energy stable. Solar panels sing. Transmitters glow. Bridges reconnect.
- **Relationships grow:** trust unlocks new dialogue, personality shifts, and gated story reveals. NPCs remember what the player said and change how they speak over time. Some NPCs move between islands based on what the player has done.
- **Social links compound:** befriending one NPC changes how others react. The girl's backpack opens doors with the old man. The merchant drops prices when his family is treated well.
- **Each fix leads to the next:** biomass fuels the burner, the burner keeps the pod alive, the pod keeps the robot moving, and the next island holds the next broken thing.

What the Player Does

- Explores four floating islands from a top-down isometric view
- Gathers wood, stone, metal, and biomass by swinging a wrench at resource nodes
- Repairs broken buildings — burners, solar panels, energy towers, storage units — each teaching a different system
- Manages pod energy: the robot's power is finite, burners extend it, solar sustains it
- Talks to AI-driven NPCs through a full dialogue system — portraits, typewriter text, suggested replies, trust meter, knowledge journal
- Builds trust through conversation, unlocking secrets, discounts, and items (the girl's backpack, the old man's rope)
- Trades with merchants — buying resources, buying buildings, and finding that relationships change prices
- Solves environmental puzzles — wind-blocked plateaus, crate-pushing, broken bridges, vertical climbs with rope
- Scans old technology to recover memory fragments that piece together the story of robots that came before
- Watches NPCs move between islands based on player actions
- Tracks objectives through on-screen indicators
- Repairs a final transmitter that links back to the base, completing the demo

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What Makes It Distinctive

1. NPCs That Actually Remember

Every NPC conversation runs through a live language model with persistent memory. The NPC recalls what the player said sessions ago, references prior topics, and reveals information based on trust — not dialogue trees. No two players will have the same conversation. The NPC's personality shifts based on how the player talks to them. This is not branching dialogue. It is a relationship.

2. Fixing, Not Fighting

The core action is care. You do not destroy overgrowth — you tend it, and it becomes fuel. You do not hack the transmitter — you feed it. You do not demand answers — you earn them. Every system in the game reinforces the idea of patient repair. Even the hit feedback — screen shake, particles, hit-stop — is built to feel good without feeling violent.

3. Social Links, Not Dialogue Trees

Relationships in [WORKING TITLE] compound. Befriending the girl changes the merchant's prices. Carrying her backpack changes the old man's reaction. Helping the old man's island makes him leave home to visit his family. The player does not unlock dialogue branches — they change how people feel about them, and those feelings spread across the islands.

4. A World That Reacts to Care

Islands change as the player fixes them. Solar panels brighten and sing. Transmitters glow. Wind chimes ring more often. Bridges reconnect. An old man leaves his museum to visit his granddaughter. The world does not just track progress — it shows it.

5. Solarpunk Without Lecturing

The game is about regeneration, interdependence, and technology working with nature — but it never tells the player this. The themes come through play: what you cut becomes what you feed. Nothing is wasted. A fixed thing sings.

6. Each Island Teaches Something New

The four-island demo is structured so each island introduces one or two core ideas while keeping the wider game in view. Island 1 teaches survival and repair. Island 2 teaches relationships and trade. Island 3 teaches puzzles and salvage. Island 4 ties it together. The player finishes the demo having used every system — gathering, building, trading, scanning, puzzling, trusting, repairing.

7. Built to Scale

Each island is a self-contained chapter: new environment, new NPCs, new story, new puzzles, new resources. The signal relay at the end of each island opens the next. The format works for episodic releases, early access chapter drops, or a full sequential game.

Development Progress — What Is Already Built

The following systems are working today in a playable build of the first island. This is not a design document — it is a list of what runs.

Player and Movement

- Full 2D isometric character controller with acceleration, deceleration, and diagonal movement scaling
- 16-direction animation system with 112 clips — the player sprite matches movement direction in real time
- Animation speed scales with actual movement speed (moving through dense grass plays the run animation at half speed)
- Multi-tier elevation system: the player can walk on top of raised platforms, walk underneath them with occlusion fade, and transition between height levels via ramps
- Battery system: 0–100 power, passive drain, action costs (swinging, scanning, etc.), low-battery warnings, and a debug toggle for infinite power
- 4-slot inventory with stacking, auto-collect, manual pickup, currency routing, held item visuals, and item dropping

Resource Gathering and Tools

- Wrench swing with animation-timed hit detection — the hit lands on a specific frame, not on button press
- Resource nodes with health, stage-based sprite transitions (the plant visibly changes as you hit it), and cross-fade between stages
- Six resource types configured: overgrowth, tree, stone, metal scrap, tech trash, flora
- Drop spawning with arc trajectories — items fly toward the player and auto-collect
- Tool effectiveness table — different tools deal different damage to different resources
- Per-hit debris burst: sprites with velocity, gravity, spin, and fade
- Resource death animation: topple and fade out

NPC and Dialogue System

- Full dialogue UI with portraits, typewriter text, suggested replies, trust meter, and chat history
- Live language model integration — the NPC generates responses in real time, not from pre-written scripts
- Persistent memory: the NPC stores every conversation in a local database and recalls relevant facts using semantic search (meaning-based, not keyword-based)
- Trust system: 0–100 scale, persists between sessions. The NPC reveals secrets at trust thresholds (40, 50, 60, 70, 75)
- Signal system: the NPC can fire story events during dialogue — unlocking objectives, triggering scene reactions, revealing clues
- Knowledge journal: the player collects entries from NPC conversations and world scans, tracked across sessions
- Two-stage island authoring pipeline: a narrative designer writes a story bible, which is converted into structured island data (NPCs, knowledge, signals, objects)
- One complete island designed and built: 1 NPC with 33 knowledge entries, 14 story signals, and a full trust-gated reveal arc

Transmitter and Power

- Transmitter station with a power pool that decays over time
- Fuel feeding: the player feeds resources into the transmitter to raise its power
- Threshold gate: when power crosses a threshold, a barrier opens
- Processing stations: consume biomass, convert to transmitter power
- Solar collectors: start dirty and dim, can be cleaned to provide steady power
- Signal relay: final objective that requires sufficient power and all solar collectors cleaned

Interaction and Scanning

- Hover system: objects highlight when the player’s cursor is over them
- Interactable system: configurable key, range, prompt text, and event wiring — no custom code needed per object
- Scan system: hold a key to scan objects, draining battery, showing a progress bar, and revealing lore text

World and Environment

- Wind system: global wind direction and strength, with per-sprite wind weights — grass, trees, and foliage sway
- Flora system: dense grass slows the player and shakes based on movement speed
- Water with animated scroll, wave shader, and submersion masking (where the player meets the water, a foam outline appears)
- 16 custom shaders for sprites, water, grass, shadows, and outlines
- Depth-based sprite sorting: objects higher on screen render behind objects lower, giving the isometric view correct overlap
- Grass decal scattering: procedural placement with minimum spacing inside polygon areas
- Pushable crates with physics — designed to act as windbreaks

Effects and Feedback

- Slash arc effect: a crescent-shaped swing visual generated at the hit point
- Camera shake on hits
- Hit-stop: brief time freeze on impact for weight
- Sprite flash on damaged objects
- Hit impact: particle burst, expanding ring, and floating damage numbers — all generated at runtime with no asset dependencies

UI

- Player HUD: battery bar and inventory hotbar
- Dialogue panel: full layout with portraits, text, suggestions, trust bar
- Scan UI: progress bar and lore result
- Resource health bars: visible over resource nodes
- Knowledge journal: entries, secrets, and tasks tabs
- On-screen interaction prompts
- Objective tracker: active and completed objectives shown as chips on screen

Audio

- Audio manager that plays sound effects based on game events (hits, pickups, swings, transmitter feeds, battery warnings)
- Procedural audio: typewriter ticks, journal chimes, trust-up tones, and secret-unlock sounds — all generated in code, no audio files needed
- 10 sound effect profiles defined (hit, break, swing, pickup, jump, land, grapple, transmitter feed, battery low, battery empty) — audio clips not yet assigned

What Is Designed but Not Yet Built

- Jump mechanics: the infrastructure exists (elevation, landing validation, animation clips), but the jump controller has no logic yet
- Wind and terrain effect zones: designed and prototyped in a separate sandbox scene, not yet in the main game
- Pushable crate puzzles: physics component exists, puzzle logic not wired
- Underground mining: tool types and resource types defined, no mine scene built
- A second island (Windroot Hamlet) is fully designed with 7 NPCs, a complete story bible, and structured data — ready to build

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Why the MVP Matters

The demo proves the concept end-to-end:

- **The core loop works:** explore, fix, talk, build trust, open the next route. Every step has feedback and story payoff.
- **The AI NPC system works:** live dialogue with memory, trust-gated secrets, signal-fired story events, and a knowledge journal. The NPC feels like a character, not a chatbot.
- **The world reacts:** grass sways, water ripples, solar panels sing, chimes ring, transmitters brighten. Islands change as the player fixes them.
- **The social chain works:** the girl, the backpack, the old man, and his movement between islands proves that relationships can be both emotional and functional — and that players will remember it.
- **The emotional hook lands:** players care about the transmitter within minutes. Finding a broken maintenance robot — like the player, on the same mission, that did not make it — is quiet and affecting.
- **The framework scales:** island content is data-driven. A second island with 7 NPCs is fully designed and ready to build. The authoring pipeline turns story bibles into playable content.

The MVP shows that a small team can deliver a polished, technically grounded, emotionally engaging game.

Demo Ending / Hook for the Larger Game

When the player repairs the final transmitter on Island 4, it connects to the base transmitter on Island 1. The network turns on.

The player has spent 30 minutes learning that this world is full of broken things — and that a small, patient robot can fix them. They have gathered, repaired, traded, befriended, solved puzzles, scanned the memories of a dead robot, and watched an old man walk home to his family.

Now the transmitter is on. The signal reaches out.

> *Another island. Another voice.*

The player knows there are more islands out there — each with its own sleeping systems, its own stories, its own people waiting to wake. The demo ends not with a cliffhanger but with an invitation.

The next island — **Windroot Hamlet** — is already fully designed: a wind-bent repair village where wind is memory, with 7 NPCs, a breathing memory-cave, and a community facing a question: *what do we keep, and what do we let the wind carry off?*

Final Tagline

[WORKING TITLE] — Fix what was forgotten. Wake what was left behind. Reach the next island.